junior employees of the East India Company. The Maratha Ditch has been filled up but its outline is discerned in the 1842 map as the Upper Circular and Lower Circular roads—and they continue to be the city's arterial roads to this day, albeit with new names.

For anyone familiar with Kolkata, the 1842 map is very interesting because many of the basic contours of the modern city are clearly visible. The old Fort William has been replaced by the large star-shaped fort that is still used by the Indian Army as its eastern headquarters. The British town planners left large open spaces around the new fort in order to allow a clear line of fire for the fort's cannons. These are now the parks of the Maidan. The Victoria Memorial, of course, does not exist at this stage and its site is occupied by a complex marked as the Grand Jail. However, the site of the Turf Club already has a race course. Well-known roads such as Park Street and Camac Street have taken shape and are clearly marked. But for the fact that many of the street-names have been changed since the 1970s, one could probably find one's way around most of central Kolkata by using the 1842 map—especially since the old names remain in common use in many cases. The map also shows how, by the mid-nineteenth century, the rapidly growing city was spilling out of the confines of the old city limits marked by the former Maratha Ditch. We can see how the new suburbs of Sealdah, Ballygunge and Bhowanipur are just beginning to appear. Their conversion into fully urban settlements would happen very gradually. I remember that even in the early 1980s, some parts of Ballygunge retained a semi-rural feel with large bungalows, fish-ponds and weekly village markets. These open spaces are now occupied by multistorey residential towers, but some reminders of the past remain: the idiosyncratic lanes, the odd hut amidst modern buildings, the old village shrine stranded in the middle of the road.

By the mid-nineteenth century, Calcutta was not just a commercial and administrative hub, but also the centre of intellectual and cultural activity. Indians from across the subcontinent came here to seek their fortune. There were even sizeable communities of Jews, Armenians, Greeks and even Chinese in the city. Although these communities have dwindled in recent decades, they have left behind buildings and place-names that recall them.